CREATIVE DIRECTIONS

Three identity directions for ARCHIVE — a digital museum of Nigeria's creative history — each argued, compared and costed, followed by the one recommended for the build. Specimens are structural: they show how each system behaves, not final artwork.

01	The Masthead	Concept · States · Markers
02	The Absent Object	Concept · Space
03	The Signal	Concept · States
04	Recommendation	The direction to take forward



ARCHIVE · CREATIVE DIRECTIONS

**ONE WORDMARK.
FOUR STATES.**

DIRECTION A

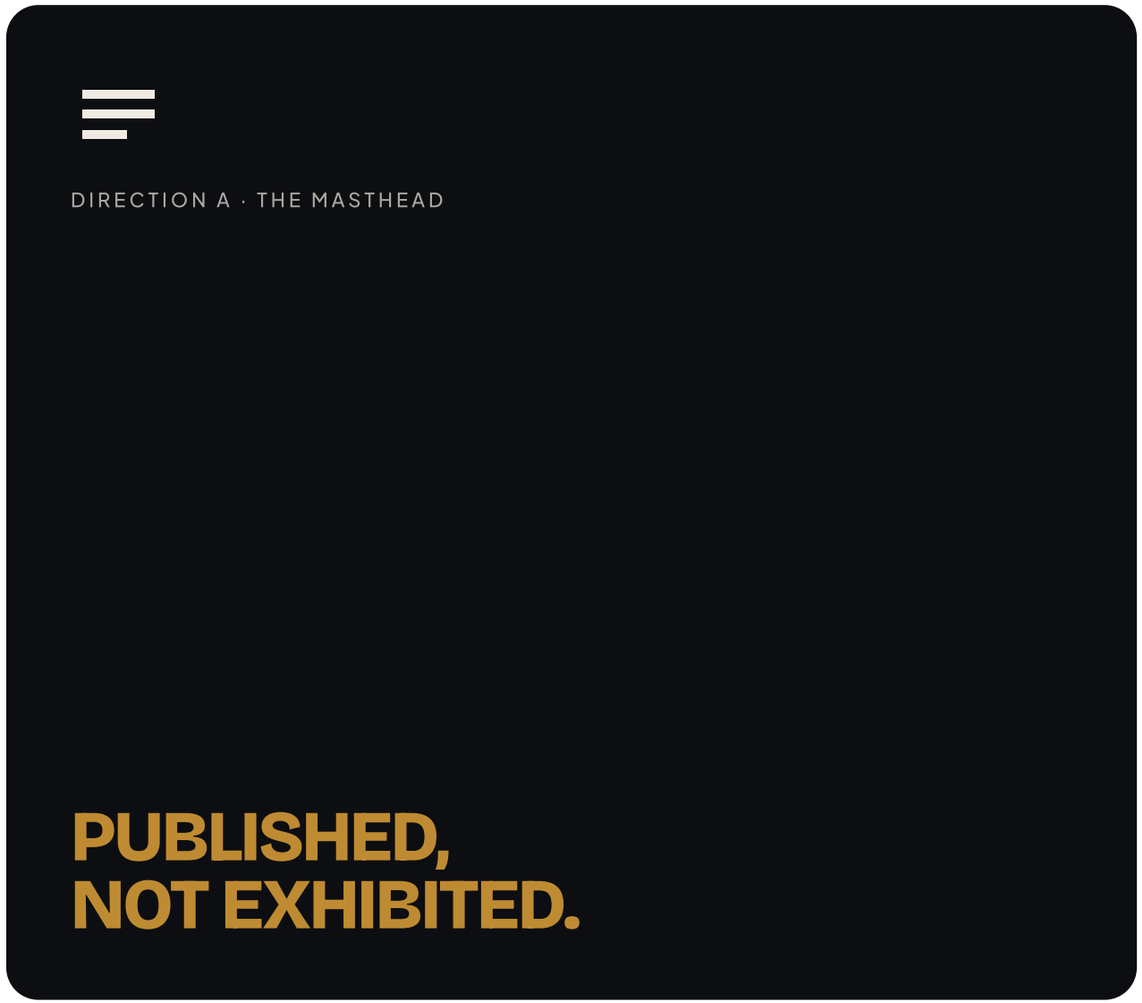
ARCHIVE is published, not exhibited. A dark, type-led cultural publication whose masthead, folio line, issue number and credit columns do the work that photographs would normally do. It borrows authority from the magazine shelf rather than the museum vitrine — which is where the research locates the tone this audience already trusts.

THE PROPOSITION

- PUBLISHED, NOT EXHIBITED
- TYPE CARRIES THE CULTURE
- CREDITS ARE THE DESIGN

WHAT CARRIES IT

- MASTHEAD AND FOLIO
- HONESTY MARKERS
- PLATE SECTIONS



FOUR STATES

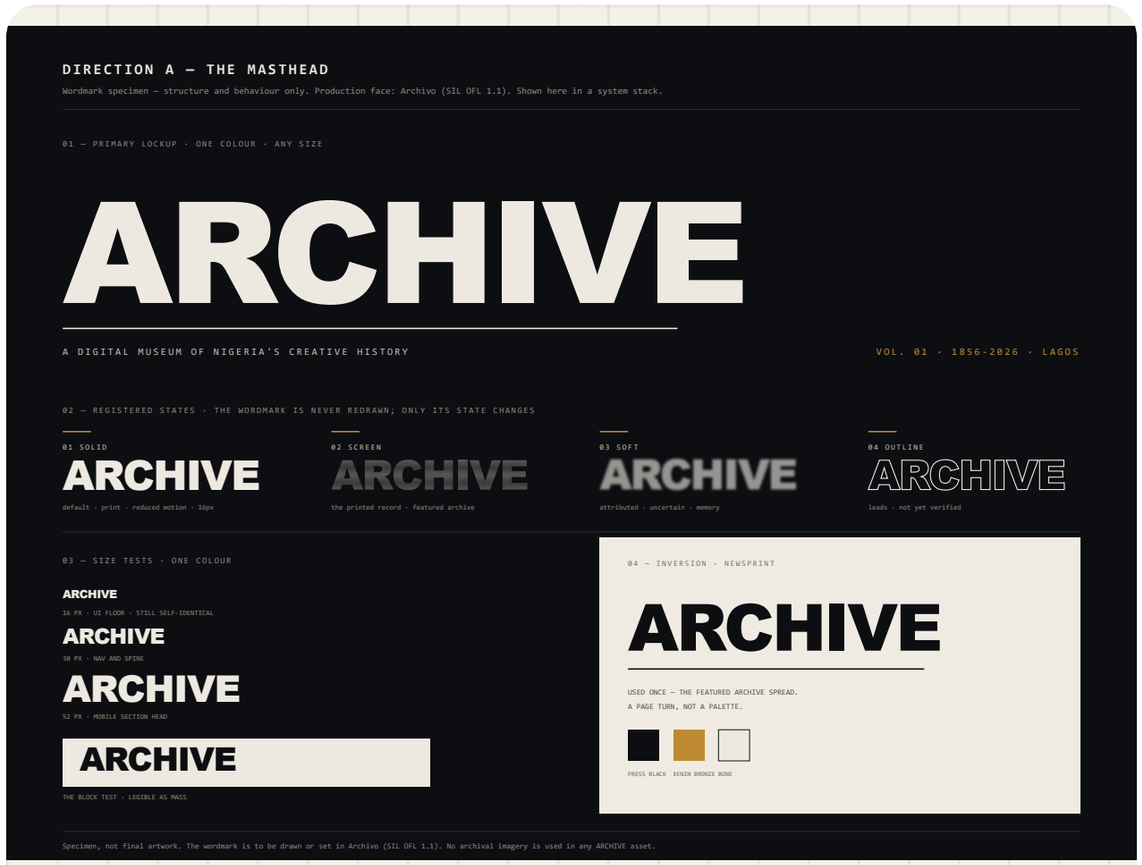
The wordmark is never redrawn — only its state changes. Four registered states, finite and named. The state encodes how much the page trusts a claim, so the design system itself carries the honesty rule the project is built on.

REGISTERED STATES

- 01 SOLID · DEFAULT, PRINT, 16PX
- 02 SCREEN · FEATURED ARCHIVE
- 03 SOFT · UNCERTAIN MATERIAL
- 04 OUTLINE · LEADS ONLY

PRODUCTION FACE

- ARCHIVO · SIL OFL 1.1
- CHARIS SIL · RUNNING TEXT
- SPACE MONO · THE CATALOGUE LAYER



SPECIMEN · STRUCTURE AND BEHAVIOUR, NOT FINAL ARTWORK

MARKERS

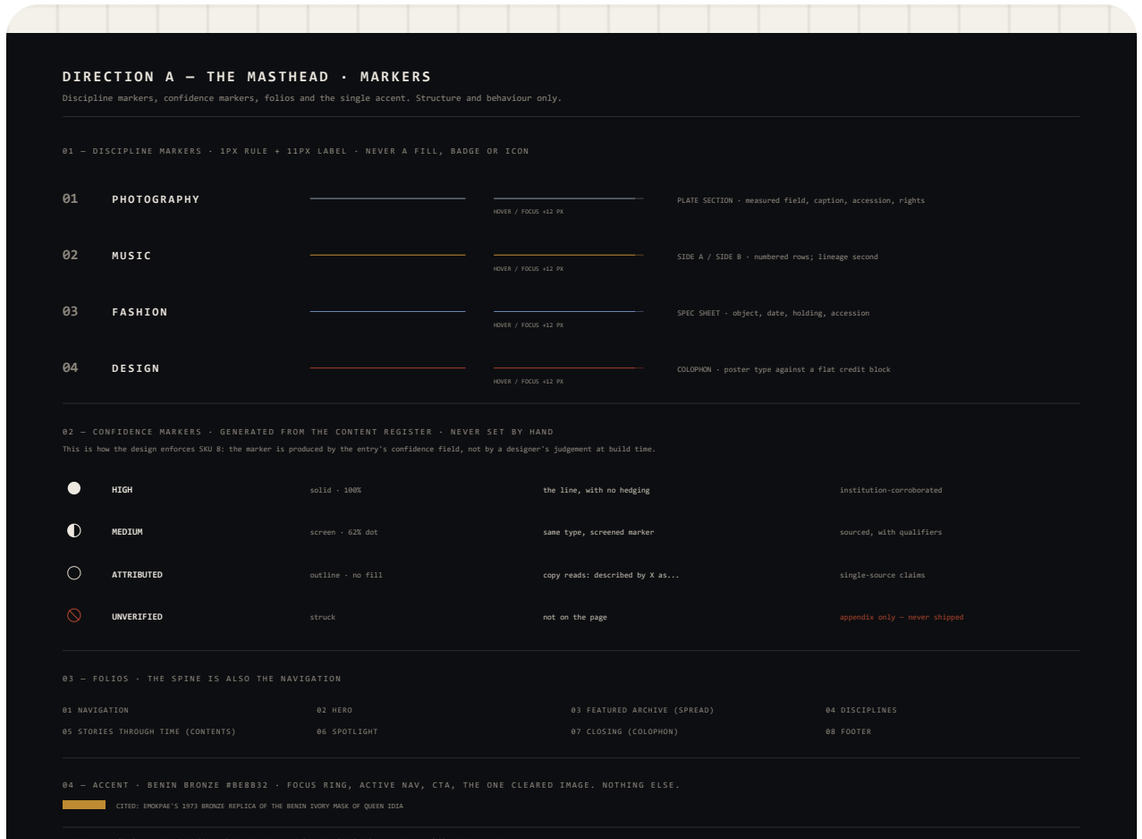
Discipline markers are a one-pixel rule and a label — never a fill, never an icon. Confidence markers are generated from the content register, never by hand, so a claim cannot be presented as stronger than its source.

CONFIDENCE

- HIGH · CORROBORATED
- MEDIUM · SINGLE SOURCE
- ATTRIBUTED · THIRD-PARTY CLAIM
- UNVERIFIED · NOT ON THE PAGE

DISCIPLINES

- PHOTOGRAPHY
- MUSIC
- FASHION
- DESIGN



SPECIMEN · MARKERS AND FOLIO, NOT FINAL ARTWORK

DIRECTION B

ARCHIVE is a room built around what it cannot show. Every absence is titled, dated, measured and attributed, so the institution abstracts its own space rather than the cultures it holds. The most interesting of the three documents, and the one that centres the limitation instead of the work.

THE PROPOSITION

- A ROOM, NOT A PAGE
- ABSENCE IS THE SUBJECT
- EVERY VOID IS NAMED

RISK

- ONE READING ONLY
- COPY-HEAVY, NO WRITER BUDGETED
- WORST PATH AT 75% FINISHED

DIRECTION B · THE ABSENT OBJECT

A ROOM AROUND AN ABSENCE.

ABSENT OBJECTS

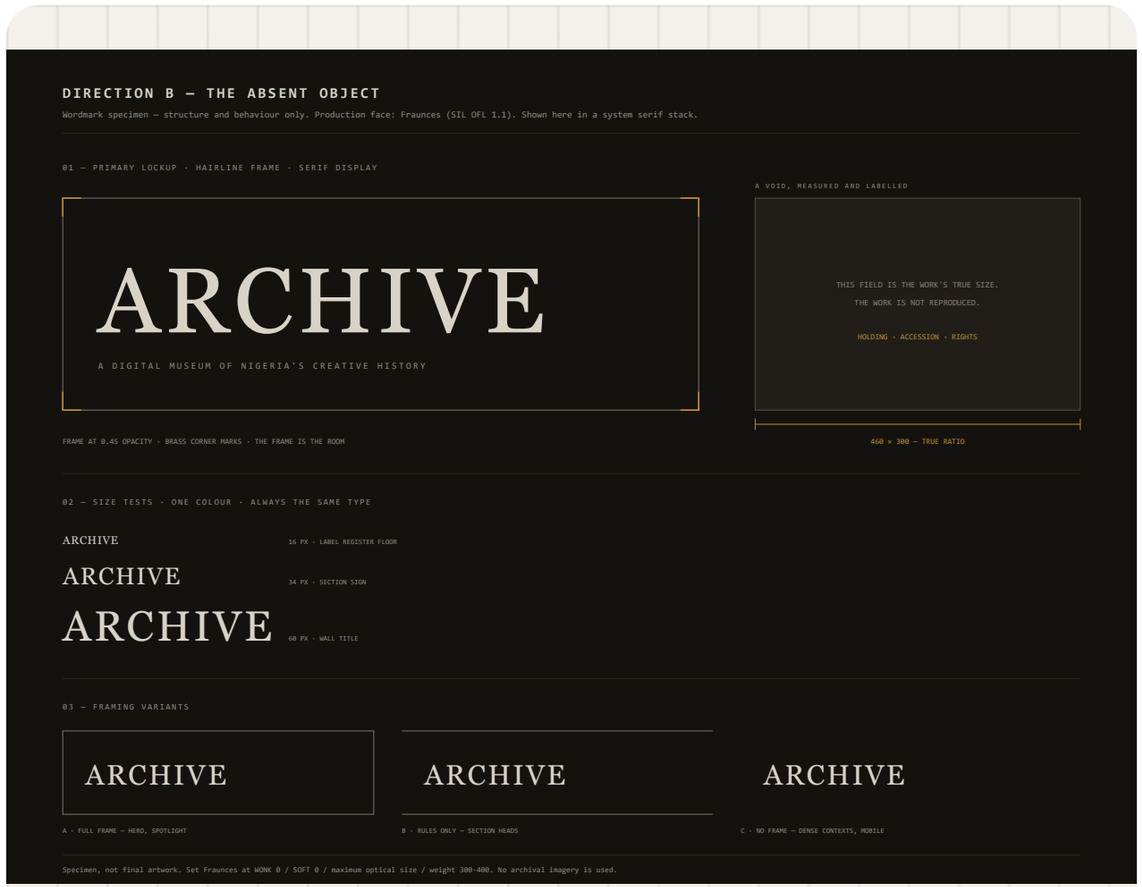
A hairline-framed lockup in a wall-label register, with measured voids that carry aspect ratio, dimension lines and the holding institution. Its one transferable idea — never let an absence be silent — is imported into the recommended direction, where it costs almost nothing.

REGISTER

- HAIRLINE FRAME
- HIGH CONTRAST
- LABEL, NOT HEADLINE

GROUND

- WARM BLACK
- MEASURED VOIDS
- WAYFINDING NUMBERS



SPECIMEN · STRUCTURE AND BEHAVIOUR, NOT FINAL ARTWORK

DIRECTION C

ARCHIVE is a transmission that never stopped. One invariant re-ordered across time is the identity, built on a citable Nigerian principle: Uli practice holds the vocabulary fixed and makes the ordering the creative act. The strongest historical argument of the three, and the hardest to build accessibly.

THE PROPOSITION

- A LIVE INSTRUMENT
- FIXED VOCABULARY, VARIABLE ORDER
- THE TIME AXIS IS THE LAYOUT

RISK

- NOT BUILDABLE TO STANDARD
- HARDEST TO MAKE ACCESSIBLE
- LIVING SIGN SYSTEM AS INTERFACE



THE SIGNAL

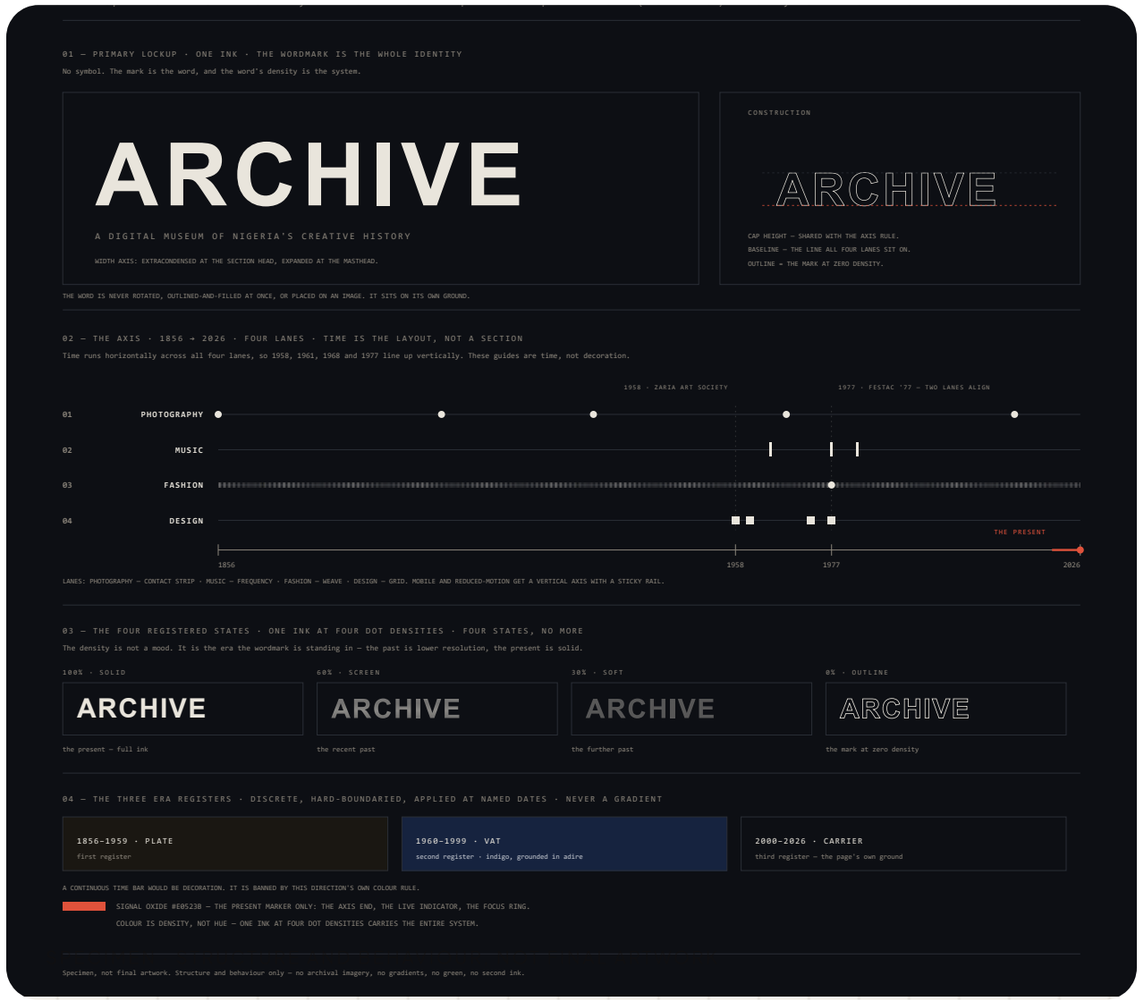
The wordmark in true dot-screen states, across three era registers, on an axis ticked 1856 · 1958 · 1961 · 1968 · 1977 · 2026. Its best contributions — registered states as the identity mechanic, and a marker system for the disciplines — are absorbed into the recommended direction without its build and cultural risk.

MECHANIC

- TRUE DOT-SCREEN STATES
- THREE ERA REGISTERS
- ORDERING IS THE IDENTITY

GUARD

- NO MARK WITHOUT MEANING
- MEANING MUST BE SOURCED
- UNDOCUMENTED MARKS UNCLAIMED



RECOMMEND-ATION

Take Direction A — The Masthead — forward, with two imports: the absence policy from B, and the registered-state and marker mechanics from C. A is the only direction that wins on both halves of the same decision: distinctive and culturally grounded, and buildable, accessible and usable by one person inside the budget.

TAKE FORWARD

- A · THE MASTHEAD
- + B'S ABSENCE POLICY
- + C'S STATES AND MARKERS

WHY

- SURVIVES BEING UNFINISHED
- TURNS THE RIGHTS LIMIT INTO A FEATURE
- MAKES THE HONESTY RULE ENFORCEABLE

ARCHIVE · RECOMMENDATION

TAKE A FORWARD.